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[00:14:12] The House will come to order. Members, please take your seats. Head page. The House is now in session. All persons not entitled, the privileges of the floor, who's retired to the gallery. The members will rise and be led in prayer by Rabbi David Witzer, Senior Rabbi and Spiritual Leader, Temple Banach Shalom, Fairfax Station, and remain standing for the Pledge of Allegiance to the Flag of the United States of America, which will be led by the Delegate from Alexandria, Delegate Herring.

[00:14:42] My thanks to Delegate Laura Cohn for the invitation to offer the invitation today. appreciation to all of you for being here and I want to wish a blessed and meaningful Ash Wednesday to all those who celebrate. In Jewish communities around the world this week we read in the book of Exodus the instructions for the building of the Mishkan, the tabernacle, the portable sanctuary that the Israelites would travel with through the wilderness. It is constructed from their freewill offerings, precious metals and fine linens, wood and tanned skins, offerings from all of those who are whose hearts so moved them and skillfully crafted together by artisans contributing their

[00:15:21] talents the mishkan served as a visible sign of god's presence in their midst a eternal spirit of the universe you have blessed the people of our commonwealth with an abundance of things that they might offer to our communal enterprise the kindness to care for one another the fortitude to endure trials and hardships the compassion to see in others a reflection of themselves the strength of character and

spirit to stand firmly for their beliefs, the patience to understand perspectives not personally shared, the desire to exercise their freedoms and ensure that others

[00:15:58] can exercise theirs, the determination to make our world a better place. O God, let these be our offerings of our hearts that we bring to you, using our skills and talents to build a society worthy of your presence. Let this House of Delegates guide and govern our commonwealth, that it may always be a home to decency, uprightness, and goodness.

[00:16:22] May they govern with fairness and justice for all. And together we say, amen. The members will answer the roll call by indicating their presence on the Electronic Voting Board.

[00:17:12] Clerk will close the roll. Mr. Speaker, a quorum is present. Pursuant to House Rule 3, I've examined and approved the General of the House of Delegates for February 17, 2026. Motions and resolutions under Rule 39, pursuant to the provisions of Rule 40, are now in order. Does the clerk have any announcements or communications?

[00:17:27] No announcements or communications at this time, Ms. Speaker. So, therefore, in this first portion of the morning hour, I'm sure the House Rule 40 speaker requests you use your request to speak button for the agenda items listed for reference up on the voting board. The delegate from Fairfax, Delegate Cohen. Thank you, Mr. Speaker.

[00:17:43] Mr. Speaker, I rise for the purpose of an introduction. The delegate has the floor. Thank you. Mr. Speaker, today's moving invocation was given by my friend and rabbi, Rabbi David Widzer, the senior rabbi and spiritual leader of Temple B'nai Shalom in Fairfax Station, Virginia. Rabbi Widzer's journey began with a deep commitment to learning.

[00:18:01] He earned his bachelor's degree in Judaic Studies and Ethics and Political Philosophy from Brown University, followed by a master's degree in Hebrew Letters and Rabbinic Ordination from Hebrew Union College. Before joining our synagogue, Rabbi Witzer served as the Rabbi of Temple Bethel of Northern Valley in Closter, New Jersey.

[00:18:21] The Rabbi of Temple Et Chaim in Franklin, Massachusetts. The Assistant Associate Rabbi at Temple Shalom of Newton in Newton, Massachusetts. And as a student rabbi, Rabbi Witzer served the Bahamas Jewish congregation in Nassau, Bahamas. In 2020, he joined our synagogue, Temple B'nai Shalom, as senior rabbi, shepherding a congregation of 345 families and more than 150 religious school students through the COVID-19 pandemic.

[00:18:48] My kiddos were two of those. Rabbi Witzer found ways to continue prayer and study, ensuring that Jewish life continued, had meaning and connection in our community, even in isolation. He also led the community in affirming a renewed vision and mission rooted in Torah and the teachings of Reformed Judaism.

[00:19:09] Rabbi Witzer is not only a scholar and a leader, he is a compassionate presence during life's most vulnerable moments for so many families in our community. He is cherished not only for what he teaches all of us, but also for how he teaches it. With generosity of spirit, intellectual depth, humor, and genuine humanity.

[00:19:29] He's not only a wonderful rabbi, but a loving husband to Karen and a great dad, to Judah and Elisheva. On behalf of Delegates Tran and Helmer, who are also members of his congregation, I ask my

colleagues to join us in giving Rabbi David Woodser a warm house welcome.

[00:19:54] Welcome to the Capitol, and thank you for that lovely prayer this morning. A delegate from Washington County, Delegate O'Quinn. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for the purpose of an introduction. Delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker.

[00:20:10] joining us today are students and faculty from Virginia Highlands Community College and I would ask that they please rise. Delegate Cornette and I both represent their coverage area. They've traveled here from their campus in Abingdon with students, faculty members, and their president, Dr. Adam Hutchison. They faithfully served the city of Bristol, Washington County, and Smith County for nearly 60 years, Mr. Speaker. They made incredible strides in tailoring a campus that that fits the needs of the area that it serves, offering a lot of programs that are fantastic for employers in our region.

[00:20:44] It really is hard to imagine what Southwest Virginia would look like without Virginia Highlands Community College. So, Mr. Speaker, I would ask that we give them a warm house welcome.

[00:21:02] Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today. The delegate from Arlington, Delegate McClure. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I rise for two motions. Delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, first I'd like to take up out of order House Joint Resolution 127 on page 1 of today's calendar and move adoption of the resolution, and then I move that when the House adjourns today, it adjourned in the honor and memory of Jalen Martinez, and I'd like to speak to those motions.

[00:21:26] Clerk, report a resolution. Page 1, Memorial Resolution, slate on the Speaker's table. House Joint Resolution 127, celebrating the life of Jalen Martinez. The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, members of the House, I rise with profound grief alongside the gentleman from Hanover, Delegate Fowler, to honor his constituent Jalen Martinez, a bright young life taken far too soon.

[00:21:50] Jalen was just 13 years old. He was a son, a friend, a teammate, and a shining light in his community. In his brief time with us, he made tremendous impact. Jalen stood out not only for his extraordinary talent on the basketball court, where he worked tirelessly and inspired those around him, but for his heart, his kindness, and his generosity toward others.

[00:22:13] In his eighth grade season, Jalen led Liberty Middle School in Hanover County to an incredible 9-1 record and a county championship, emerging as one of the leading middle school scorers across Virginia. His work ethic and competitive spirit set him apart.

[00:22:29] Beyond his school team, he played for Rocket Basketball in Richmond, the nationally ranked Under Armour team out of Alabama. All in, go crazy. At such a young age, he was already competing on big stages and thriving. Prior to his passing, Jalen was planning to continue his academic and athletic journey at Benedictine College Preparatory in Goochland County this past fall.

[00:22:53] He had dreams of playing one day Division I college basketball, and at just 13, he wasn't just dreaming. He was building the foundation to make those dreams a reality. I have watched Jalen grow up since he was just a baby.

[00:23:08] His parents and I went to school together, and so many of us fondly remember baby Jalen making appearances at the VCU basketball games. He was so full of joy, making just so surrounded by community. Everyone loved him so dearly.

[00:23:25] Watching him grow into the young man he became was both a privilege and now an unbearable heartbreak. Mr. Speaker, I want to recognize Jalen's mother, Sierra Martinez, whose unimaginable grief is beyond the reach of words.

[00:23:41] Ciara is here in the gallery with us, and I want to say to her, Ciara, our hearts go out to you. We honor Jalen's life. We cannot imagine the immense grief and pain that you and your family are feeling from the loss of Jalen, a loss that no parent should ever have to endure.

[00:23:58] Mr. Speaker, the circumstances around Jalen's passing were heartbreaking in every sense, a tragic accident that occurred with a loaded firearm that was not properly stored at a friend's house. This preventable tragedy, which cuts short a promising life, is a solemn reminder of how critical this issue is.

[00:24:17] Sierra wants everyone to know that. And in the face of unimaginable grief, she has become a fierce advocate for safe storage so that no other family has had to endure this level of pain and loss. Jalen had so much ahead of him, Mr. Speaker. A young man with dreams, drive, and a gift for bringing people together.

[00:24:34] His legacy reminds us that each life, especially the life of a child, is precious and irreplaceable. As we honor Jalen today, please let us recommit ourselves to the action that protect and uplift our children and to supporting families like the Martinez family through their grief and their ongoing efforts to turn tragedy and pain into purpose and hope for others.

[00:24:58] Jalen's light was bright, and though his time here was short, the impact that he made will ripple far beyond these walls. His story does not end here. Jalen's memory and legacy forever lives on in every life that he touched and every dream he inspired, and to his mother, Sierra, his family, his friends, his coaches, and to everyone who loved Jalen, my heart goes out to each and every one of you.

[00:25:22] While nothing can fill the tremendous void that the loss of Jalen has brought and left in your family's hearts, I hope that this chamber's recognition today brings you a measure of comfort and collective support from a grateful commonwealth. And with that, Mr. Speaker, I move adoption of House Joint Resolution 127 and move that when the House adjourns today, we adjourn in the honor and memory of Jalen Martinez.

[00:25:46] The Delegate from Arlington, Delegate McClure, moves the adoption of House Joint Resolution 127, celebrating the life of Jalen Martinez, and that when the House adjourns today, it adjourns in the honor and memory of Jalen Martinez. Those in favor of the motion shall rise.

[00:26:05] The motion is agreed to. Delegate from Virginia Beach, Delegate Tata.

[00:26:27] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for a purpose of an introduction. The Delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Today, I have the distinct honor of introducing an outstanding group of students from Frank W. Cox High School Young Republicans Club. Thank you for rising.

[00:26:43] These young leaders have demonstrated an early and inspiring commitment to civic engagement and public service. They understand that the strength of our republic depends on the active participation of its citizens, and they are here today to learn how to better serve their community and uphold their shared values.

[00:27:01] I hope it's the will of the body to join me in giving these young patriots, well actually Falcons, a warm house welcome. Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today.

[00:27:21] The delegate from Albemarle, Delegate Carlson. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I request permission to take the center aisle for a presentation for the Outstanding Virginian of the Year. The delegate may take the center aisle. Thank you.

[00:27:37] Mr. Speaker, any delegate that wishes to join me may do so in the center.

[00:27:45] Clerk will report a resolution.

[00:28:34] House Joint Resolution 133, commending the Honorable J. Harvey Wilkinson III. This legislation is passed the House February 13th, passed the Senate February 16th, 2026. Delegate from Albemarle, Delegate Carlson. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. It is my honor and privilege to present the 2026 Outstanding Virginian of the Year, the Honorable Harvey Wilkinson III.

[00:28:58] Judge Wilkinson has enjoyed a distinguished and decades-long public service career culminating in his appointment and service as a circuit judge on the United States Court of Appeals in the Fourth Circuit. Before becoming a judge, he started off with a solid educational background attending St. Christopher's School in Richmond, Virginia, Lawrenceville School in New Jersey, and then traveling further north to Yale University, where he was president of the Yale Political Union and graduated Phi Beta Kappa and Magna Cum Laude. He then returned home and received his law degree from the University of Virginia, where he was on the Virginia Law Review and was later awarded the Thomas Jefferson Medal, the highest outside award offered by that university.

[00:29:38] Having attended both those institutions myself and in that order, but with a whole lot less of accolades to show for it, I think his good judgment was already apparent from a young age. Beyond his education, or actually perhaps in addition to it, he also served in the United States Army Reserves for six years, based in Charlottesville, where he rose to the rank of E5 as a company clerk. Thank you, thank you.

[00:30:06] That's why I told y'all to come join me up here. Background help. He did take a short break from law school when he left in 1970 to run for Congress in the Richmond area. He recalls that billboards at the time urged voters to send Satterfield back to Congress and Wilkinson back to law school.

[00:30:25] The voters generously took him up on that suggestion. He received the Republican nomination but lost by more than 2-1 in the general election. And thus, he returned to law school. When I read his bio, it became readily apparent that he is a true polymath.

[00:30:45] We'd be here a long time if I mentioned all of his accomplishments, and one cannot condense a lifetime of service into one speech. Here's a really quick overview, because I'm going to try to do honor to the award and the lifetime of service that you've had. He was clerk for the U.S. Supreme Court Justice Lewis Powell, and today, still to this day, regards Justice Powell's measured and balanced, approach to his job as a model of what a judge should be. He was a professor at UVA Law, where he still maintains lifelong friendships with his students. He was an editor of the Norfolk, Virginia Pilot, embracing the opportunity to involve himself in important local issues in

[00:31:24] the Tidewater region. He served under the Reagan administration as a deputy assistant attorney general in the Civil Rights Division of the Department of Justice. And he was then appointed by Reagan to be circuit judge for the United States Court of Appeals for the Fourth Circuit. His 41-year tenure was the longest in the history of that court and one of the longest in the history of our nation.

[00:31:48] He served on a variety of boards. Please look at the resolution for more. There are too many to list. And perhaps of importance to me, he's also the author of several books, many of them with very hefty weights, titles, educational material. But two of them, one is a personal memoir, All Falling Faiths, and a romantic novel, Love at Deep Dusk, which is available on Amazon with good reviews.

[00:32:15] So the list goes on with one perhaps overarching theme, a life of service to our nation and our commonwealth. As a constitutional scholar, he holds high the founder's vision of our democracy, that our judicial branch be an equal branch of government entrusted with and trusted as faithful and fair interpreters of our laws, the laws we have the privilege of voting on in this body.

[00:32:41] Judge Wilkinson expressed to me the hope that our judicial system will continue to serve as a beacon of liberty and as an anchor of independence in these most divisive of times. And with that, I ask that we all extend a sincere thank you to Judge Wilkinson for his lifetime of service and a congratulations for his recognition as Outstanding Virginian of the Year.

[00:33:08] Mr. Speaker, our students, or his grandchild and my son go to school together, so another little bonus. He's everywhere.

[00:33:37] Well, congratulations, Judge Wilkerson. It's a great honor, and we're happy to have you and your family here in the Virginia House of Delegates. Thank you and congratulations. The House will be at ease.

[00:35:45] The House will come to order.

[00:37:47] Delegate from Grayson County, Delegate Cornett. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for the purpose of an introduction. Delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. It's my pleasure today to recognize representatives from Withfield Community College, if they'll please rise. Withfield Community College serves students across Southwest Virginia, including the counties of Bland, Carroll, Grayson, Smith, Wythe, as well as the city of Galax, and Delegate Moorfield and Delegate Williams represent these areas with me, alongside me.

[00:38:17] And today, the members of the college's leadership team are with us, as well as some outstanding students who represent the future workforce and leadership of our region. Whitfield Community College plays an essential role in providing affordable education, workforce training, and opportunity for the families and communities of southwest Virginia and our surrounding areas.

[00:38:40] So it's my pleasure to introduce them today, and I hope it's a pleasure of the body to give them a warm house welcome. Welcome, welcome to the Capitol today.

[00:38:57] The delegate from Loudoun County, Delegate Reed. Yes, Mr. Speaker, thank you. I rise for the purpose of an announcement. Delegate has the floor. Okay, for everyone's benefit, tomorrow is going to be the Military Appreciation Night. This is hosted by the General Assembly Military and Veterans Caucus.

[00:39:13] It will be tomorrow from 6 to 8 p.m. at the Virginia War Memorial. And food will be provided by Mission Barbecue. And everyone is welcome. So thank you, Mr. Speaker. The delegate from Hanover, Delegate Fowler. Thank you, Mr. Speaker.

[00:39:30] I rise for an announcement. The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Members of the House, please come and join Betsy Carr and I for the Virginia Legislative Sportsman's Caucus tomorrow morning at a late hour of 7 a.m. in the seventh floor House North Subcommittee meeting room.

Mr. Speaker, our special guest is Cully McCurdy, a district biologist for the National Wild Turkey Foundation. Ms. McCurdy will discuss the National Wild Turkey Federation's long-term investment in wildlife conservation, utilizing the Superfund dollars in addition to

[00:40:06] the National, well, excuse me, the NWTF's partnership with the Virginia Department of Wildlife Resources. Hope to see you there in the morning. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. The delegate from Roanoke City, Delegate Rasul.

[00:40:31] Mr. Speaker, I rise for the purpose of an introduction and an announcement. The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. First, I'd like to introduce Virginia Western Community College, the students and staff from there. Virginia Western Community College is recognized for its strong programs in healthcare, life sciences, biotech, and aligns with the workforce needs.

[00:40:55] I had the pleasure of being able to meet with some of the students there this morning, and they certainly are well on their way to doing some great things. They, I think probably every single person in my family has taken classes there, and I hope that the House can give them a warm House welcome.

[00:41:14] Welcome, welcome to the Capitol today. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, on behalf of the two billion Muslims worldwide and the quarter million Virginia Muslims, I'd like to welcome you to the season of Ramadan, where we begin our fast from dawn until sunset of food and water.

[00:41:42] But amongst many other things, we try to improve ourselves as human beings. Mr. Speaker, my kid one time recently came up to me and said, I love being in the season of Ramadan. And they're like, why? And I said, why? She said, because we have to eat dinner together every night.

[00:42:01] And so it forces us to come to the dinner table, put our busy lives aside, because you know what? If you've been fasting all day, you are hungry. But we are fortunate today, Mr. Speaker, to be joined by the nearly 1.8 billion brothers and sisters who are celebrating the season of Lent.

[00:42:22] These seasons actually come together for not only fasting, but reflection. We think that, Mr. Speaker, that the heart needs training. And this is our 30 days to train. Number one, to train to the things that we shouldn't be doing.

[00:42:39] Number two, trying to do some of the things that we probably should be doing better. That community and family certainly matters. And that restraint, Mr. Speaker, sometimes is a form of freedom. Sometimes when we can restrain our tongues and restrain our actions, it frees our spirits in lots of ways. So, for those of you who would like to visit a local mosque, every evening there is an iftad, a dinner. I'm happy to connect you with a local mosque here in Virginia. And there's going to be an iftad reception. Senator Salim and myself welcome you

[00:43:14] next wednesday the 25th to have an iftad with us and mr speaker you know during this season we tell our kids that you're not going to change who you are as a person significantly but if you can figure out a way to get one percent better then maybe it's been a good season so we hope you can join us in trying to just be a little bit better over the next 30 days thank you mr speaker delegate from camel county delegates there thank you mr speaker i rise for an introduction delegate as

[00:43:53] floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Joining us in the gallery today, members from the Brook Neal Town Council. If the town council made it up there, would you please stand? And Brook Neal is one of the most American little towns you've ever run into, and is here today to look at ways to improve tourism to

Brook Neal. So after session, you need to get out of Richmond. Go to Brook Neal. You won't regret it. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Welcome, welcome, welcome to the Capitol. There he is.

[00:44:23] Welcome, welcome to the Capitol today. Now, how do you get to Brook Neal? You didn't give direction. He said, just go. The delegate from Henrico, Delegate of Vera Bowling. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for the purposes of an introduction. The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker.

[00:44:40] Today in the gallery, we are joined by employees from Dominion Energy who work in a variety of fields, helping to keep the lights on across the Commonwealth, and I ask if they're in the gallery to please stand. They are here today listening to the legislative process in action as they are focused on their mission of providing reliable, affordable and increasingly clean energy to power their customers every single day.

[00:45:03] With that, Mr. Speaker, I ask that we give them a warm house welcome. Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol. Welcome back for one of you guys.

[00:45:19] The delegate from Fauquier County, Delegate Weber. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I rise for an announcement. Delegate has the floor. If I could get Delegate Simons to come join me.

[00:45:37] Sounds like a belt transfer process.

[00:45:54] Yeah, you got to put it over the shoulder like WWE. All right, here we go. Alright, so Mr. Speaker, we had the great oyster eating contest sponsored by the Chesapeake Bay Foundation and a number of producers that produce the fine oysters that we love to eat here in Virginia.

[00:46:13] And Mr. Speaker, the contest was fantastic. It was close. It was so close, so close. But first, I'm going to work from the folks that participated on down to our winner. And Mr. Speaker, Delegate Pence, has been working on TMDL and best management practices funding over the course of this session, advocating for it to clean up our bay.

[00:46:43] And unfortunately, he was disqualified because the belt wouldn't fit. We discovered this. He told me I could use it. He told me I could use it. Comedy's hard, Mr. Speaker. Caucus on caucus crime.

[00:46:58] Comedy's hard. Now, we also had Delegate Anderson, who actually showed up early to the contest. However, she did not take advantage of the rules and get started immediately. So that kind of slowed her down a little bit. And her spirit, which was one of the rules, was not quite there.

[00:47:17] Now, Mr. Speaker, Delegate Simons was, I mean, she ate a lot of oysters. Actually, all of us ate a lot of oysters. The steamed were probably my favorite. But she recycled her t-shirts from last year, Mr. Speaker.

[00:47:33] And if you're going to have spirit, it's got to be brand new spirit. And Mr. Speaker, I was disqualified because I had to leave early for a press conference. So, Mr. Speaker, the winner of this year's oyster eating contest is Delegate Phil the Pearl Hernandez.

[00:48:06] Come over here. Come over here. Come over here. So, Mr. Speaker, not only did he show up on time this year.

[00:48:30] First time ever. First time ever. But he ate an amazing amount of oysters while we were there. I think he probably would have won it in the first half hour. So without further ado, Mr. Speaker, the winner of the Chesapeake Bay Foundation's oyster eating contest, Phil the Pearl Hernandez.

[00:48:51] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Okay. Congratulations, Pearl.

[00:49:07] Is that what they call you? The Delegate from Prince William, Delegate Sewell. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for an introduction. The Delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker.

[00:49:23] Mr. Speaker, in the gallery today, we have members of the Realtor Association of Prince William and ask them to please stand. The association represents nearly 1,800 realtors involved in all aspects of real estate serving Prince William County and the surrounding areas.

[00:49:40] They are here today advocating on a range of issues from housing access and property rights to general affordability for the communities they serve. Realtors play a critical role in promoting and protecting the right of all Virginians to achieve home ownership, and we appreciate their engagement in the legislative process. Mr. Speaker, I ask that members of the body join me in extending a warm house welcome. Welcome, welcome to the Capitol today. The Delegate from Spotsylvania, Delegate Scott. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for the purpose of an introduction.

[00:50:19] Delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I am pleased to introduce a delegation from Germanna Community College, if they'd please rise, representing the Commonwealth's 23 community colleges. Germanna Community College serves as a key driver of workforce preparation and economic development across its service region, directly supporting the communities represented here today.

[00:50:39] Joining us are Dr. David DeRay, Chancellor of the Virginia Community College System, Dr. Tashika Griffith, Germanna's seventh president, and four Germanna students. Together, they represent the nearly 235,000 students served annually by Virginia's community colleges through academic transfer, career and technical education, and short-term workforce credential programs.

[00:51:04] As workforce needs continue to shift across Virginia, Germana Community College remains responsive to local and regional demands. The college delivers training in high-needed areas such as healthcare, information technology, trade skills, and advanced manufacturing, ensuring employers have access to a prepared, ready workforce.

[00:51:27] Virginia's community colleges are a proven, cost-effective solution to meeting Commonwealth's workforce needs. Through employer partnerships, short-term credentials, and workforce development initiatives, Germana helps close skill gaps while strengthening local economies. Most graduates remain in Virginia, contributing directly to their communities and to the districts we all represent.

[00:51:49] Looking ahead, Germana Community College, under the leadership of its new president, Dr. Griffith, continues its commitment to student success, workforce readiness, and economic growth. Together, we are supporting Virginia's communities by building a skilled workforce that strengthens families, businesses, and the Commonwealth as a whole.

[00:52:08] If you'd please join me in giving them a warm house welcome. Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today. Delegate from Norfolk, Delegate Glass.

[00:52:26] Gratitude, Mr. Speaker, I rise for an announcement. Delegate has the floor. Gratitude, Mr. Speaker. Next week, Monday, there's a football game happening. I mean, a basketball game that's going to be happening. And for those of you who's got bad knees and maybe a bad back, we're offering the opportunity to play, I was going to say play, to bowl.

[00:52:48] So on Thursday night for members, we're asking that you let either myself or Delegate Weber know we've got six lanes reserved at River City Bowl and food and bumper lanes for I think Fowler and small we got and also have reserved a little thing where you could put the ball on it and push it down if you don't have the back strength anymore but it'll be a good time no cause other than camaraderie care and just making the house of delegates do what it does

[00:53:25] best. Gratitude, Mr. Speaker. The delegate from Botatite, Delegate Austin. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I rise for introduction. Delegate has the floor. Mr. Speaker, I'd like to recognize the students, faculty, staff, and President Dr. John J. Ranone, who are proudly representing Mountain Gateway Community College. Would you please rise? Since 1962, Mountain Gateway has served the counties of Allegheny, Bath, Northern Botatite, and Rockbridge County, as well as the cities of Buena Vista, Covington, and Lexington, providing accessible, high-quality higher education to the region. Originally established as a branch of Virginia Tech and formerly known

[00:54:04] as Dabney Lancaster Community College, the institution has evolved into Mountain Gateway Community College, now serving more than 1,800 students. The college offers comprehensive programs in health care, skilled trades, information technology, business, and is especially proud to provide the Commonwealth's only two-year degree in forestry. I would hope it's the pleasure of the body to give Mountain Gateway Community College a warm house welcome.

[00:54:35] Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today. The delegate from Lynchburg, delegate Walker. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for introduction. The delegate has the floor.

[00:54:51] And Mr. Speaker, before I introduce my guest here today, as a point of information here, the Oyster Day is the highlight of my General Assembly activities here. Now, while there's a lot of consumers of this great product of Virginia, somebody has to shuck those oysters.

[00:55:11] And I delight in being a country boy from Georgia, shucking these oysters, and I can shuck them as fast as Delegate Simon can consume them. So we need to have another ward in the future, the fastest oyster shucker.

[00:55:27] Now back to what I really wanted to talk about. I have some great friends here today. Joining us in the gallery today are grassroots leaders with the Americans for prosperity, Virginia. I ask that they stand to be recognized. These citizens are small business owners, parents, professionals, and community leaders who deeply care about the future of the Commonwealth.

[00:55:53] They have taken time out of their schedules to be here in Richmond meeting with members of our bodies, engaging in legislative process. Their presence here today is a strong reminder that citizens involved in the foundations of good government, we appreciate their dedication to staying engaged and their commitment to the principles that help Virginia thrive.

[00:56:14] I'd ask that the House give these folks a nice, warm welcome. Thank you. Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today. Delegate from Richmond, Delegate Carr.

[00:56:31] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for an introduction. Delegate, that's the floor. Thank you, sir. Ladies and gentlemen of the House, it is my great honor to welcome today to the gallery community college students, faculty, and staff who have traveled to Richmond from across the Commonwealth. I'd ask them to stand now, please.

[00:56:48] Originally scheduled to be with us earlier in the session, They have persevered despite the challenges of weather and travel to share with us their stories of how Virginia's community colleges have changed their lives. Many of these students have benefited from second and third chances to reach their academic and workforce dreams.

[00:57:09] Community colleges have provided a level playing field that has given thousands the chance they needed to succeed. I believe some of them will also be introduced by other delegates, as you have also heard. But it is my honor to introduce the VCCS as a statewide system with more than 5.5 million alumni and 230,000 students each year, Virginia's community colleges touch nearly every household in Virginia through affordable degree pathways, through workforce credential programs that provide a fast track to the workforce, and through high school dual enrollment that gives

[00:57:48] students a chance to step up to their college careers. Virginia's community colleges this year celebrate 60 years of service to the Commonwealth. That's six decades of transformative education. Today, nearly half, 46 percent, of public undergraduate students in the Commonwealth get their start at Virginia Community College. Today in the House Gallery will be or have been Delegations from Germanna, Laurel Ridge, Mountain Gateway, New River, Pauldy Camp, Rappahannock, Virginia Highlands, Virginia Western, and Whitfield Community College.

[00:58:28] I'd ask my colleagues to please join me in welcoming them today, the students, faculty, and staff from Virginia's 23 community colleges. Welcome, welcome to the Capitol today.

[00:58:49] Delegate from Dinwiddie, Delegate Pope Adams. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I rise for the purpose of an introduction. The delegate has the floor. Thank you. Today in the gallery, we are joined by representatives from Virginia State University.

[00:59:05] I ask them to stand. Mr. Speaker, high atop the Appomattox where proud banners fly, stands a legacy that time simply cannot deny.

[00:59:23] Founded in 1882 with purpose, vision, and grace, I rise to welcome the Virginia State. Their alumni, students, and faculty shape much of what we see, Trojans serving in both chambers of the General Assembly.

[00:59:42] Though near or far, wherever we roam, not one of us ashamed to call Virginia State our home. And yes, our friends from Norfolk last week came down the spar. Their green and gold is valiant, I'll grant them that far.

[00:59:58] But lest they forget, we are their wiser, older brother. An institution so great it could govern others. But don't worry, Mr. Speaker, I won't tempt my fate. I'll instead devote my energy to welcoming Virginia State.

[01:00:16] So let us rise today in tribute and in cheer, for it's the Trojans' presence we're honored by here. So, Mr. Speaker, with the love in my heart I dare you to replicate, please join me in extending a warm house welcome to the Virginia State.

[01:00:37] Welcome to the Capitol. That was a first.

[01:00:53] That was a first. So I guess now I know it's, I guess we know what's going to happen from here on in. Everybody got to try to, everybody got to try to one-up her now. The delegate from Winchester, Delegate Wiley. That's a hard act to follow.

[01:01:11] You better have some rhymes. Mr. Speaker, I rise. Mr. Speaker, I rise for your introduction. The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, ladies and gentlemen of the House, it's my pleasure today to welcome students and faculty members from Laurel Ridge Community College. May it please rise. Where it proudly serves the Chandoval Valley in Northern Virginia, Laurel Ridge plays a vital role in preparing our workforce, supporting transfer pathways to four-year institutions, providing affordable, high-quality education to students of all ages and backgrounds.

[01:01:42] We are grateful for the commitment these students and educators show to their studies, their communities, and the future of the Commonwealth. Please join me in extending them a warm house welcome. Thank you. Welcome.

[01:02:01] Welcome to the Capitol today. Delegate from Middlesex, Delegate Hodges. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for the purpose of an introduction. Delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Ladies and gentlemen of the House, please join me along with Delegate Kent to recognize the president of Rappahanna Community College, Dr. Shannon Kennedy, and the students at RCC.

[01:02:22] Rappahanna Community College has been opening its doors to opportunity across Virginia's Middle Peninsula and Northern Neck since 1970 and is the only post-secondary institution in the 12-county service region. The college offers two transfer degrees with seven majors, associate and applied science degree in criminal justice, business, nursing, diagnostic medical stenography, and engineering.

[01:02:49] RCC also offers certificates in high-demand fields and 16 industry-recognized certifications in short-term programs. The college serves approximately 3,000 credit students and 500 credential students each semester.

[01:03:05] And in talking with these students, Mr. Speaker, earlier today, they all plan to live and stay and work in Virginia. Mr. Speaker, I ask the House to give a warm welcome to the president and students, the remarkable students from Rappahannock Community College.

[01:03:24] Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today. Delegate from Giles County, Delegate Ballard. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for the purpose of an introduction. Delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker, members of the House. Joining us in the gallery today are students and staff from New River Community College, led by its new president, Dr. Robert Brandon.

[01:03:46] I ask that they please stand. Members of the House, New River Community College is located in my district in the town of Dublin and has been serving the citizens of the New River Valley and beyond since 1969. NRCC's mission emanates from that of the community college system. We give everyone the opportunity to learn and develop the right skills so lives and communities are strengthened. Mr. Speaker, these folks traveled about three and a half hours one way and they met in my office today and I think with Delegate Franklin and some others and we are just so so honored to have them here today. So I hope it's the pleasure of the house to give them a

[01:04:21] warm house welcome. Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today. Delegate from Hanover, Delegate White. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for an introduction. Delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker.

[01:04:38] Today, we met Delegate Fowler, myself, and Senator McDougal met with the folks, the second half of the Grace Christian School folks that were here earlier. We had very robust conversation from the

historical significance of the Virginia State Capitol, as well as the first mace that It was presented by the royal governor in 1700 in silver then to the House of Delegates.

[01:05:03] They decided to come to the House side as opposed to the Senate side after discussion with Fowler and I. A few fishing facts were thrown in, but I would ask all members of the House to please join me in giving them a Warren House welcome. Thank you. Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today.

[01:05:27] The delegate from Sussex, Delegate Waxman. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I rise for two introductions today. The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, the first introduction, I'd like to recognize students and their teacher from Tidewater Academy, if they could rise.

[01:05:45] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. These students and teacher is their government class, part of the government class from Tidewater Academy, located in the suburbs of historic Wakefield, Virginia. They've come here today to watch the legislative process in action. I had a chance to meet with them for about 30 minutes, found out that they were very well-versed in the organization called the General Assembly and how our bills walk across.

[01:06:09] It is my pleasure to recognize them today. After meeting with me, they toured the Capitol, and they're finishing their day here today. I would like to ask if my colleagues in the chamber could give them a warm house welcome.

[01:06:30] Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. And now for my second introduction, I'd like to introduce the faculty, staff, and students from Pauldee Camp Community College, if they could rise. Pauldee Camp Community College is located in Franklin, Virginia.

[01:06:50] They serve the areas of Franklin, Sussex, Suffolk, Southampton, and Isle of Wight. I share their service territory with Delegate Nadarius Clark, who, of course, is not able to be here today. But they are here today with their students representing those areas that they serve.

[01:07:08] Recently, they have expanded their workforce development area and launched their first lab school in maritime studies in Smithfield. So I'd like to welcome them here and hope that my colleagues will also share a warm house welcome with them.

[01:07:34] Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. DELEGATE SIMONS: The Delegate for New Point News, Delegate Simons. DELEGATE SIMONS: Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I rise for the purpose of an introduction. DELEGATE SIMONS: The Delegate has the floor. DELEGATE SIMONS: Today in the gallery, we have members from Virginia Organizing, if they could please stand.

[01:07:54] Virginia Organizing has been advocating for social justice for over 30 years with chapters across the Commonwealth. Their grassroots efforts have addressed housing, education, health care, equality, and civic engagement. They empower communities by amplifying the voices of those who have historically been marginalized, and by working collaboratively, democratically, and nonviolently to create meaningful, lasting change across the Commonwealth.

[01:08:22] I hope it will be the pleasure of the body to give them a warm house welcome. Welcome, welcome to the Capitol today. The delegate from Bonitoc, Delegate Austin.

[01:08:41] Mr. Speaker, I rise for introduction. Delegate on the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Joining us today in the chamber is the Honorable Judge G. Stephen Agee. Judge Agee, would you rise? Judge Agee served in the House of Delegates from 1982 to 1994, representing Salem and Renwick County.

[01:09:00] He then went on to serve on the Virginia Court of Appeals from 2001 to 2003, the Supreme Court of Virginia from 2003 to 2008, and in 2008 he was appointed to the U.S. Court of Appeals for the Fourth Circuit, where he currently serves. I've had the pleasure of getting to know the judge and his wife and son, Zach, for over the years.

[01:09:19] I can say without reservation that their love and respect for the Commonwealth and his dedication to services second to none. I would hope the pleasure of the body would join me in giving Judge A.J. a warm house welcome. Welcome, welcome, Judge. And don't forget me when I'm before you.

[01:09:48] The delegate from Loudoun County, Delegate Reed. Mr. Speaker, I rise for the purpose of an introduction. The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Today we are joined by members of the Loudoun County Democratic Committee, if they could please rise. Along with my colleagues in Loudoun County's delegation, I am proud to welcome these dedicated volunteers to the Virginia State Capitol today.

[01:10:09] Their hard work and commitment to our democratic process contributed to a historic outcome in Loudoun County this past election, reflecting their tireless organizing and strong engagement with the community. These volunteers serve year-round, engaging with the community, registering voters, and promoting civic participation.

[01:10:27] Their work does not end on Election Day. It is a non-stop commitment to ensuring every voice in Loudoun is heard. Today, they represent all eight magisterial districts of Loudoun County, and I thank them for their dedication. And I hope it will be the pleasure of the body to give them a warm house welcome.

[01:10:48] Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today. Delegate from Rockingham. Delegate Runyon. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I rise for the purpose of an introduction. The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, today in the gallery, we are joined by members of ARC of Herzenberg and Rockingham, one of the 21 local chapters of the ARC of Virginia, the only statewide advocacy organization representing Virginians with all types of developmental disabilities and their families.

[01:11:20] They're in Richmond today for the Blue Ridge Developmental Disability Advocacy Day, advocating for increased rates of essential waiver services, supports for families and caregivers, and preserving and protecting accessibility and exclusion through their daily lives. The Arc of Virginia and its chapters have been steadfast advocates for decades here in the General Assembly, working with legislators and policymakers to ensure that Virginia continues to work towards opportunities that are shaped by the people they are meant to serve. I would also like to highlight for my colleagues that there is currently an exhibit set up in the GAB

[01:11:55] entitled A Life Like Yours, which celebrates the stories, advocacy, and collective work of Virginia's developmental disability community. Folks are welcome to go and view the exhibit on the 10th floor between now and March 10th. I ask my colleagues to please join me in offering a warm house welcome to these very special folks. Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today. Delegate from Norfolk, Delegate Hernandez. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for the purpose of gloating,

[01:12:33] I mean for an introduction please. The delegate has the floor. Thank you Mr. Speaker. Today we are very fortunate to have faculty and staff from the Virginia School for the Deaf and Blind in Stanton, Virginia. I would ask them to rise if they are able. Mr. Speaker, VSDB was created by the General Assembly

in 1838. Opened its doors to students for the first time in 1839 and what is so cool about this treasure of a school is that it is the first school in the nation that brought

[01:13:08] together deaf students and blind students on the same campus. We trailblazed that path here in the Commonwealth. It is one of the great honors that I have as a delegate to serve on the board in my capacity here and to help get the school what it needs. But they do such tremendous work and I just wanted to say thank you for coming here today and it's good to see you and i would ask that the house extend a warm welcome to these wonderful folks phil delegate hernandez help me say welcome to

[01:13:48] the capital sign language do it for me pursuant to house rule 30 the journal shall reflect that the following members are away on pressing personal business and are granted leave from today's session delegates clark hamilton knight law firm mcculler phillips price and where clerk Clerk will announce the next order.

[01:14:16] Mr. Speaker, the second and third portions of the morning hour are not applicable given today's calendar. Clerk will announce the next order. Fourth and final portion of the morning hour is reserved for points of personal privilege. Clerk will call the calendar. Calendar for today, the first day after crossover, this Wednesday, February 18, 2026.

[01:14:33] The only live category, memorial resolutions laid on the speaker's table. HJR 127 has already been dispensed with. Therefore, there is no further business coming before the House today. Pursuant to House Rule 51, the House is returning to the morning hour. Does the clerk have any additional announcements on communication?

[01:14:49] Communication announcement to the body that as soon as we adjourn, I'll be swearing in the newest member here, Delegate-elect McPike. In light of that and in light of this afternoon's committee schedule, the speaker has sent to me, I've made the following committee assignments and changes effective today.

[01:15:09] Delegate Carnegie appointed the Committee on Public Safety. Delegate, soon to be Delegate McPike is appointed to the Committee on Finance and the Committee on Public Safety. And Delegate Pope Adams, excuse me, is removed from the Committee on Public Safety and appointed the Committee on Transportation.

[01:15:27] So we'll update the list and share that with you. In addition, I would remind the body I sent out to everybody how to handle Senate bills, how the House will process Senate bills instead of going through that. Here, just look at your email and how the Senate will be communicating with you.

[01:15:43] will be forthcoming later this afternoon. Looking ahead to this afternoon, we have appropriations is not meeting today. So the first meeting will be 15 minutes upon adjournment of the House. Delegate Watts' Committee on Finance will be meeting.

[01:15:59] They'll be in House Committee Room B on the second floor. Then 15 minutes upon adjournment of the Finance Committee, the full Courts of Justice Committee. They'll be next door in House Room C. Once they are finished, then they'll split up the two committees.

[01:16:14] The criminal subcommittee, of course, will remain in House Room C. However, the civil subcommittee will meet 15 minutes upon adjournment, but they'll go down the hall to House North subcommittee. So finance and then courts and then two subs. The last caucus meeting I'm aware of this

afternoon is the LGBTQIA plus caucus, which is meeting at 5 up on the – they are not going to be meeting today, so they're getting a day off, and we will change that accordingly.

[01:16:42] Looking ahead to tomorrow, Thursday, February 19th, Capitol Commission prayer meeting at 6.30, followed by the Bible study at 7 on the 14th floor of the Speaker's Conference Room. Legislative Sportsman's Caucus was already mentioned. We'll be meeting at 7 a.m. in the 7th floor meeting room, North Meeting Room.

[01:17:00] The Hampton Roads Caucus is meeting tomorrow at 7.30. They're going to be in the 7th floor south subcommittee room, so Sportsman and Hampton Roads Caucus is next to each other there at 7.30 to 7 tomorrow. County, cities, and towns, subcommittee number two will be meeting at 7.30.

[01:17:18] They'll be in the house south subcommittee room 210, which is on the second floor. Health and Human Services Behavioral Health subcommittee is canceled. However, at 8.30, the full committee will be meeting and House Committee room C on the second floor. Once full HHS is finished, then its subcommittee on health professions will be meeting immediately upon adjournment.

[01:17:38] I think it was mentioned earlier, the Aviation Caucus is having something, a reception tomorrow night, but they're having a caucus meeting at 8 a.m. tomorrow. They'll be on the sixth floor, north subcommittee room, on the sixth floor of the seventh floor over in the GAB. And then at 9 o'clock, the full committee on transportation is meeting.

[01:17:56] They'll be on House Committee Room B on the second floor. Then going in at noon, the two Coxes will be meeting earlier, Republican Coxes meeting at 11 tomorrow, and Democratic Cox at 11.15, 11.30 tomorrow, and Democrats in House Room 1, Republicans in House Room 2.

[01:18:14] All of this is listed online as well, Mr. Speaker. That's all the announcements I have, sir. Delegate from Alexandria, Delegate Herring. Mr. Speaker, I move that when the House adjourns today, adjourn to reconvene tomorrow at 12 noon. Delegate from Alexandria, Delegate Heron moves that when the House adjourn is there, adjourn to reconvene tomorrow at 12 noon.

[01:18:31] As many in favor, the motion will say aye. Those opposed, no. The motion is agreed to. Delegate from Alexandria, Delegate Heron. Mr. Speaker, I move that the House do now adjourn. Delegate from Alexandria, Delegate Heron moves that the House do now adjourn. As many in favor, the motion will say aye. Those opposed, no. The motion is agreed to. The House stands adjourned until tomorrow at 12 noon.

